

Module 0 — Intro & Setup

Lesson 0.2

Setup & sanity check

Install Claude Code, authenticate, and confirm the moving parts work.

Mastering Claude Code — An E-Course for Power Users

Why it matters

Half of the friction beginners report with Claude Code is misconfigured setup — wrong shell, wrong auth, wrong permissions mode. Get this clean once and forget about it.

The mechanics

Install

Native CLI (recommended):

```
# macOS / Linux
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

```
# Windows (PowerShell)
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

Or via npm if you prefer pinning a version in a project:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Verify:

```
claude --version
claude --help
```

Authenticate

You have two options:

- 1 **Subscription auth** — `claude login` (uses your Claude.ai Pro/Max/Team account)
- 2 **API key** — set `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` in your shell environment

Subscription auth is the simplest for individuals. Use the API key when you need finer billing control, are running in CI, or building with the SDK.

First-run sanity check

In any project directory:

```
claude
```

Inside the session, try:

```
> /help
> /model
> ls and describe what you see
> /clear
> /exit
```

If `/help` lists slash commands, `/model` shows your current model, and the third prompt produced a sensible reply, you're set.

Pick a default permissions mode

Claude Code can run with different permission modes:

- **Default** — prompts you before tool use that's not on the allowlist

- **Plan mode** — read-only; Claude plans but cannot edit, run shell commands, or push changes
- **Auto-accept (a.k.a. "dangerous" mode)** — runs everything without prompting (use only in sandboxes)

You enter plan mode mid-session with Shift+Tab (toggles modes) or by passing `--permission-mode plan` at launch. We'll spend a whole lesson on this in 1.4 Plan mode.

Set up a project for this course

```
mkdir claude-course-sandbox && cd claude-course-sandbox
git init
claude
```

Inside the session:

```
> /init
```

`/init` generates an initial `CLAUDE.md` based on what it sees. We'll improve it in 3.1 `CLAUDE.md`.

Try it

- 1 Install Claude Code and run `claude --version`.
- 2 Start a session in an existing repo of yours.
- 3 Run `/help`, then `/model`, then `/agents`, then `/hooks` and skim what each shows. You don't need to understand it all yet — we'll cover each.
- 4 Exit and re-enter with `claude --resume` to confirm session resumption works.

Gotchas

- **Windows path quirks** — Claude Code on Windows defaults to a bash-like shell. Use forward slashes in commands and quote paths with spaces.
- **API key not picked up** — confirm with `echo $ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` (or `$Env:ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` in PowerShell). Restart your shell after setting it.
- **Outdated install** — `claude` updates itself, but on locked-down systems you may need to re-install. Check `claude --version` periodically.
- **Permissions in CI** — the default permissions mode prompts interactively, which hangs in CI. Use `--permission-mode acceptEdits` or `--dangerously-skip-permissions` for CI runs (carefully, in sandboxed environments only).

Further reading

- Official install docs: <https://docs.claude.com/en/docs/claude-code/quickstart>
- Permissions: <https://docs.claude.com/en/docs/claude-code/iam>

Next

→ 1.1 The CLI surface